

BJP MAKES HISTORY BY FORMING ITS FIRST-EVER GOVERNMENT IN THE

THE GATEWAY TO SOUTH

■ By Stephen David and Swagata Sen

At around 10 p.m. on May 25, G. Janardhan Reddy, Bellary mine owner, legislator and BJP "party worker", sent his private helicopter to two undisclosed locations in Karnataka. The sorties brought back to Bangalore two of the most coveted individuals in all of the state that day—a couple of Independent MLAs. By then, BJP was in no doubt that it would form its first government in a state in south India. With a tally of 110, it was just two short of the halfway mark. The next day, at Reddy's posh flat, negotiations finally sealed BJP's numerical supremacy in the new Assembly. On May 27, as a group of party leaders was on its way to meet Governor Rameshwar Thakur to apprise him of the magic number, Reddy's house bore testimony to the activities of the previous day. Bouquets of exotic flowers lined the rooms, which other leaders, party members, advocates and businessmen entered and exited in a flurry of activity, happily partaking of the excitement involved in rewriting the history of Karnataka. Reddy, for his part, basked in the glory of his achievement. "I didn't have to do anything. One of the boys was our own, he contested as an Independent because we couldn't give him a party ticket. We are happy to have him back. The other, an ex-JD(s) member, joined the fray because hundreds of people from his constituency went to his house and asked him to join us," he said, summarising the day-long exertions. By the afternoon, all six Independents had pledged their support to BJP, taking the party's strength to 116 in the 224-seat Assembly. All six were promised ministerial berths in return. While three were flown out of Karnataka for "safekeeping" till they were actually sworn in as ministers, the others were "cared for" by Reddy. After all, he is the Mr Moneybag of the party.

Elections in different states are decided by different factors. In a Communist state like West Bengal, it is muscle and terror tactics. In the northern hinterland, it is caste and allegiance politics, among other things. In Karnataka, it is the blatant, unabashed, power of money. If one party distributed pamphlets to every house with a Rs-500 note attached, the other tucked in Rs-1,000 notes. If one party developed a sustained strategy of ask-and-thou-shalt-receive by paying lakhs for anything from dowry to hospital bills, no questions asked, the other decided that voters would be appeased by television sets and passes to get them anything from liquor to pressure cookers for free. In the end, however, the voters voted for who they wanted to—BJP got 88,57,340 votes and created history. It recorded a vote-share of 33.86 per cent, which is 5.6 per cent more than its share in the 2004

